LEISURE Q+A

CHECKMATE

17-year-old **D. Gukesh** recently overtook Viswanathan Anand as the top-ranked Indian chess player

Q. You recently surpassed Viswanathan Anand in the live FIDE rating. What did this moment mean to you and how has he influenced you over the years?
Vishy Sir is the prime reason that most of us got into chess. He has been my mentor and has been guiding me for the past three years as well. So, it makes me really happy to have surpassed him in the ratings.

Q. Magnus Carlsen was your teammate in the Global Chess League. Then you were up against him at the quarterfinal stage of the World Cup. What are the things that you have learnt from him?
It is always a great learning experience, whether you are playing alongside Magnus or against him. I try to absorb as much as I can from him. He has also been kind enough to analyse my game and share his thoughts whenever we have met, which definitely helps a young player like me.

Q. What has been your parents' contribution in making you a better chess player?
They have always been a great pillar of support and I am grateful to them for allowing me to pursue chess without any pressure. They allowed me to give up regular schooling years ago, so it's like I can now focus and dedicate all my efforts towards chess, without the burden of worrying about academics. I can say it is working out for me so far.

Q. You are only 17. What do you miss about being a regular teenager? And what do you like to do apart from chess?
I am happy with what I'm doing at present and don't think I regret or miss too many things. Apart from chess, I like to watch and play other sports like badminton, tennis, football and cricket. I also like to read books and listen to music.

with Shail Desai



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